
The Major Oscar Contender That Left Me Almost As Cold As a Nordic Winter

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In Slate's annual [Movie Club](#), film critic Dana Stevens emails with fellow critics—for 2025, Justin Chang, Alison Willmore, and Bilge Ebiri—about the year in cinema.

Greetings, my never-undesirable friends,

The last time I joined the Movie Club was five years ago, during that first COVID-impacted winter of 2020—a rather different season of turmoil for the movies, the media, and democracy, and not one I ever thought I'd look back upon with anything approaching nostalgia. In the preamble to [my own list of the best 25 films of 2025](#), I wondered, to little avail, about how a year of such thoroughgoing existential gloom, especially concerning the future of the film industry, could also have been a year of such staggering cinematic riches—in sheer numbers, at least, the most robustly rewarding movie year I can recall since before the pandemic. We're so back! Also, we're so fucked! The cognitive whiplash is real.

In any case, I'm glad to be with you all and grateful for any opportunity to pore over this medium that we love and will continue to love, stubbornly, to its final breath. As will, I'm sure, Steven Soderbergh, who, for all his oft-expressed pessimism about the industry, continues to churn out work that feels like a paragon of wit, elegance, and the kind of all-around savoir faire that we used to associate with Hollywood on a more regular basis.

That's certainly true of the spectacularly fleet and witty [Black Bag](#), starring Michael Fassbender and Cate Blanchett as British intelligence agents whose marriage comes under stealth attack from a mole. What ensues is a tour de force of sex, lies, and data scraping, Edward Albee by way of John le Carré, in which our lead agents try to suss out which of their deviously smart and sexy colleagues could be the culprit. Tom Burke, Naomie Harris, and Regé-Jean Page are all in top form, though the ensemble revelation has to be Marisa Abela, whose immortal delivery of a single line ("My God, that's ... so hot") was enough to earn her a lone vote for Best Supporting Performance, from yours truly, at the Los Angeles Film Critics Association meeting earlier this month. (It wasn't nearly enough—the two awards in that category went to Teyana Taylor for *One Battle After Another* and Stellan Skarsgård for *Sentimental Value*—but hey, it's still one more vote than Ariana Grande managed to bag for [Wicked: For Goodness' Sake Why](#).)

Alison, I was delighted to see *Black Bag* ranked so high on your list; I couldn't keep it off mine or, in the end, extricate it from [Presence](#), the other thriller that Soderbergh and the screenwriter David Koepp released this year, and one no less awash in the pleasures and perils of secret surveillance. (Throw in their terrific tail-end-of-COVID shut-in thriller [Kimi](#), and you'd have a magnificently paranoid triple bill.)

I'm also glad that you mentioned Dag Johan Haugerud's luminous *Sex/Love/Dreams* trilogy, which I'm kicking myself for *not* including on my list. One of my more obnoxious go-to lines this year has been that, with *Dreams* in the mix, the much-acclaimed *Sentimental Value*—which I know Dana loves and [has written about](#), beautifully—wasn't even the best *Norwegian* release this year. In Joachim Trier's film, Stellan Skarsgård plays a veteran filmmaker seeking to work and reconcile with his two estranged daughters, one of whom (played by Renate Reinsve) is an accomplished stage actress. It's one of several [dramas this season about bad showbiz dads](#) and the families they neglect in the selfish pursuit of their art—a subgenre capacious enough to include the globe-trotting upper echelons

of Hollywood, in Noah Baumbach's alternately sharp and schmaltzy [Jay Kelly](#), and the Globe-trotting glimpse of Elizabethan England, in Chloé Zhao's wildly divisive [Hamnet](#).

As someone trying to be a less bad, less overworked dad himself—and who, while far from sold on *Hamnet*, wept as copiously at the big Shakespearean climax as Bilge did—I don't know what it says about me that *Sentimental Value*, its faultless performances notwithstanding, left me almost as cold as a Nordic winter. Even as a stealth haunted-house movie, a rumination on how the physical spaces we inhabit accumulate indelible layers of historical, emotional, and psychological memory, it pales beside Mascha Schilinski's much more intricately considered realization of a similar concept in [Sound of Falling](#). (Seeing them both in the space of a week, at this year's Cannes Film Festival, admittedly did Trier's film no favors.) Beyond that, *Sentimental Value* struck me as oddly coy about its ostensible subject, the passionately symbiotic relationship between life and art—something that Trier explored to richer, thornier ends in 2006's [Reprise](#) and 2021's [The Worst Person in the World](#), the bookending installments of his own justly celebrated, pre-Haugerud Oslo-based trilogy.

But then, Alison, it's possible that the reticence that holds me back from *Sentimental Value* is precisely the same thing you find off-putting in [Sorry, Baby](#). I loved that film with few reservations, though I'm sympathetic to your argument—perhaps more as a general principle than in specific application to *Sorry, Baby* itself—that a character study, especially one circling an unspeakable trauma, can lean too heavily on a character's silences, gesturing toward meaning in spaces where none really exists. One critic's artful understatement can be another's maddening emptiness. The crucial difference here may simply be that I loved every minute of Eva Victor's performance, every comically arched eyebrow, every sudden dark flash of memory, and every goofily inappropriate punch line burbling up from the depths of God knows where.

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In its destabilizing use of both humor and stillness to examine the lingering aftermath of sexual assault, *Sorry, Baby* makes a fairly intuitive companion to [the equally superb On Becoming a Guinea Fowl](#), to the point where I'm tempted to unwind my list and pair them together. But where Victor's film respects the singularity of a traumatic experience, the gifted Zambian-Welsh filmmaker Rungano Nyoni takes a more expansive view. *Guinea Fowl* is about what happens after the death of

a serial rapist in the family: the systematic retraumatization of several young women forced to participate in the long, meaningless charade of mourning their abuser. I was struck by Nyoni's ability to convey her tensions and meanings almost entirely in formal terms—the way she sets the quietly watchful face of her star, the remarkable Susan Chardy, so starkly against the mourners' weeping-and-wailing group theatrics. I was also struck by the gender-blind comprehensiveness of her indictment; she brings us into a world where the patriarchy exerts its stifling power in no small part through matriarchal bullying.

I'll save *Who by Fire* for a later dispatch—or perhaps I'll kick it over to Bilge, who I know [admires this cabin-fever tour de force](#) as much as I do; for now I'll just say that the brilliant Québécois filmmaker Philippe Lesage is one of the most inexplicably well-kept secrets on the international film scene.

And, Bilge, while I have you: I love that we both handed the No. 3 slots on our lists to Jia Zhangke's wrenching archival docudrama *Caught by the Tides*, which, in its epic survey of two decades' worth of transformations across not only China but also the motion-picture medium itself, is as inspiring a mascot for cinema's enduring power as anything I can think of. It's startling to see the great Zhao Tao, in the performance of the year (and maybe the past 20-odd years), looking so young and fresh-faced in the rough, degraded digital video of the early sections—then so broken and worn down in the sharp, crystalline HD of the later sections. And yet, in a closing scene that feels like an article of faith, she keeps going. The movies, I suspect, will find a way to do the same.

—Justin

My top 25, arranged as a set of pairs (and one trio):

1. *Sir?t*
2. *One Battle After Another*
3. *Caught by the Tides*
4. *Resurrection*
5. *My Undesirable Friends: Part I—Last Air in Moscow*
6. *The Secret Agent*
7. *Sound of Falling*
8. *April*
9. *On Becoming a Guinea Fowl*
10. *It Was Just an Accident*
11. *Cloud*
12. *Blue Moon*
13. *Who by Fire*
14. *Marty Supreme*
15. *If I Had Legs I'd Kick You*
16. *The Mastermind*
17. *No Other Choice*

-
18. *Sorry, Baby*
 19. *Souleymane's Story*
 20. *Black Bag*
 21. *Presence*
 22. *Misericordia*
 23. *Wake Up Dead Man: A Knives Out Mystery*
 24. *Sinners*
 25. *Nouvelle Vague*

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